

Cleft Sentences

B2 · Upper-Intermediate · Rearrange a sentence to put the most important information front and center.

A cleft sentence splits one idea into two clauses, putting the most important piece of information first, for emphasis — very common in both spoken and written English.

Rules

a) It is/was...that

Used to emphasize a specific person, thing, time or place.

- John broke the window. → It was John who broke the window.
(emphasizing WHO)
- I met her at the conference. → It was at the conference that I met her.
(emphasizing WHERE)

b) What...is/was

Used to emphasize an action, thing, or idea — often what someone wants, needs, likes, or did.

- I need more time. → What I need is more time.
- She annoyed me by being late. → What annoyed me was her being late.

Examples

- It was John who broke the window.
- It was at the conference that I met her.
- What I need is more time.
- What annoyed me was her being late.
- It's the price that worries me, not the quality.
- What surprised everyone was his sudden resignation.

Common Mistakes

✗ It was John which broke the window.

✓ It was John who broke the window.

For a person, use "who," not "which," after the cleft "It was..."

× What I need it's more time.

✓ What I need is more time.

Only one verb "is/was" is needed to link the two clauses — don't add "it's" as well.

× Is the price that worries me.

✓ It's the price that worries me.

The cleft needs "it" as the subject at the start — don't drop it.

Summary

- It is/was...that/who = emphasize a specific person, thing, time or place.
- What...is/was = emphasize an action, need, or idea.
- Only one linking verb (is/was) connects the two halves — don't double it up.

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